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through electronic modes like Online trading, Mobile banking and e-marketing.

In this context, it is all the more important for any student to learn the historical background of the growth and development of commerce in the country in general and in Tamil Nadu in particular. An attempt is made in this chapter to explain such a history so as to ascertain the magnitude of commerce today.

The earliest trading population of India was Indus valley people, who used the word 'trade'. The word vaniyam or vanipam would have had a Dravidian origin. The early Tamils produced their products and goods in their lands and bartered their surplus and that is how trade came into existence. The word 'Vanigam' has been widely used in sangam literature like Purananuru and Thirukkural. The Tamil – Brahmi inscriptions from Alagarmalai, Pugalur, Mangulam and Sri Lanka illustrate the fact that trade in gold, oil, plough, cloth etc.was conducted during the early age.

Trade in Sangam period was both internal and external but it was conducted by means of barter (pandamattru) Trade was one of the major means of linking various regions in the medieval period. Sangam work refers to great traders, their caravans, security force, markets, marts and guilds of such great traders. The important articles which the then hilly tribes offered to their neighbours in exchange were honey and roots and fruits while pastoral people offered cattle, milk and milk products. Cattle served as money for sometimes during the same period. Most of the inland trade was done in salt as a medium of exchange under barter mode. Paddy too served as a medium of exchange



The important trade routes of the silk and spices, blocked by the Ottoman Empire in 1453 with the fall of Constantinople and the Byzantine Empire, led to the search for a sea route across the Atlantic skirting Africa.

for a certain period. There was dependence and interdependence among the people in matters of trade and commerce. Barter system cemented their relationship internally while coins were used later for the purpose of exchange of goods in external trade.

Trade and Traders in The Pandiya Dynasty

Trade and commerce was so common to Pandiya Dynasty. Information collected from the diaries of foreign travellers, voyagers, mariners and adventurers of the ancient world highlighted the prosperity of trade in the Pandiya country. The Hebrew and Latin literature, archaeological remains in Aden, Alexandria, Java, Sumatra and even China add support to the fact of existence of trade network in the Pandiya country. Trade in copper, cloth, salt, flower, sandal wood, fish, paddy, cereals, pearls, etc flourished during their period. The place where the goods were sold was called